r/NoStupidQuestions

how is ai art bad for the environment?

Posted by u/angel0fdespair • • 0 points • 19 comments

-someone who does traditional art and understands how it devalues natural/traditional art.

Comments

u/AgentElman • 0 points • 2025-04-22 00:01 UTC

This is propaganda by people who are anti-ai.

They compare the power used for generating something with AI vs. clicking an html link. They notably do not compare generating something with AI vs streaming videos.

And they add up all of the energy ever used for all AI development and claim that is being used to generate one image.

u/sapient-meerkat • 3 points • 2025-04-21 23:41 UTC

AI relies on a massive amount of high-end GPUs to do all of the processing. Like, across the big players, we're talking *millions* of high-end processors in aggregate.

Running and cooling those GPUs consumes a lot of electricity.

A lot of that electricity is generated by fossil fuels.

Burning fossil fuels is bad for the environment.

Therefore, AI (in general, not just AI art) is bad for the environment.

u/ask-me-about-my-cats • 3 points • 2025-04-21 23:34 UTC

It takes energy to generate the art.

u/N4meless24- • 1 points • 2025-04-21 23:32 UTC

To make it fast it needs big processing units, those burn a lot of vatts, fans, electricity, generators, towers, and so on.

> **u/angel0fdespair** • 1 points • 2025-04-21 23:33 UTC
>
> can i ask how it's any different than using fast internet? or is that also just as bad? and what are vatts? sorry just curious.
>
> > **u/N4meless24-** • 3 points • 2025-04-21 23:39 UTC
> >
> > On an average machine, a browser search uses a fraction that is the equivalent of a millionth of the computing power a good AI image creator uses each second.
> >
> > It'd take you a solid year of searching non stop for it to come to the power consumption of one second of image processing at 100% power usage.
> >
> > > **u/mulch_v_bark** • 1 points • 2025-04-21 23:56 UTC
> > >
> > > >the equivalent of a millionth of the computing power a good AI image creator uses each second.
> > >
> > > Could you share your source or math on that?
> > >
> > > I'm upvoting your comment, which someone downvoted apparently, but it's not matching what little I know about this issue.
> > >
> > > An H100 has a max consumption of about 700 W. Over a second, that's obviously 700 J.
> > >
> > > I think the last public statement on the energy consumption of a web search is [from 2011](https://techland.time.com/2011/09/09/6-things-youd-never-guess-about-googles-energy-use/#ixzz2A86slJ00). That's a long time ago, but on the other hand, it's probably not any *less* than that now, so I think we can treat it as a lower bound. And that's almost exactly a kilojoule, so actually *more* than a second of an H100 at full power.
> > >
> > > Now, I'm not saying my numbers are definitely good. You could pick something other than an H100, and obviously there might be better data than something from 2011. I'm not saying I've got this figured out! It just raises a yellow flag for me that our estimates are six orders of magnitude different.
> > >
> > > > **u/Lumpy-Notice8945** • 2 points • 2025-04-22 00:03 UTC
> > > >
> > > > I have downvoted the comment, because its just straigt up false, i have generated pictures on my local gaming PC(so it has a decent GPU) with stable diffusion. My PC

has a 800W power supply and takes about 1-2minutes for a single picture to generate. The only thing you can add to that is the amount of power needed to train that model, but because SD is free software there is millions using that model to generate thousands of pictures, so if you want to add this initial cost you have to average that over all the pictures generated with than model.

u/N4meless24- • 1 points • 2025-04-22 00:09 UTC

Also, to rectify, you're generating off of a WebUI on your own machine (that was still not trained by you, hence the cost is still higher than mentioned), but most people won't.

Most people will use something involving OpenAI, Gemini, BingAI or whatnot, and those have multiple hundreds of thousands of GH200 for GPU processing power, and those plus the minimum remaining specs for a server average 1000W each.

u/N4meless24- • 2 points • 2025-04-22 00:06 UTC

Sounds good dude, it's internet points, the person was asking if it was equivalent to making a browser search and it isn't even remotely close.

u/N4meless24- • 1 points • 2025-04-22 00:00 UTC

Truthfully it is really just balled out, but you're looking at a single H100, nothing else attached, and the entire infrastructure of, let's say, OpenAI probably includes amongst the thousands of those.

Nvidia reported a sale of 500000 (500k) GPUs a year or a bit more ago solely for the purpose of AI training/usage, and that wasn't a one time purchase.

u/mulch_v_bark • 2 points • 2025-04-22 00:11 UTC

Oh, hang on, I think I misunderstood. When you said “a good AI creator” I thought you meant *one image diffusion process* but I gather you meant *the whole operation*. That makes more sense. I think there’s still a gap between your estimate and mine, but it’s definitely no longer six whole orders of magnitude.

I do think the fair comparison would then be Google (or whatever other company)’s whole search operation. But really it’s: how many Watts am I responsible for at a given time? And I think the natural way to do that is one image generation to one search, which should be maybe one order of magnitude apart, maybe less now that Google attached a shitty LLM to searches.

FWIW, my own position here is that searches and image generation are both iffy, not that image generation is totally blameless. I do think ordinary people tend to get more joy out of a given image, and that has to count for something. (Ordinary people meaning people having fun, not people making uninspired illustrations for their lousy SEO blogs.)

u/N4meless24- • 2 points • 2025-04-22 00:18 UTC

That sounds reasonable, I agree with all of it.

u/mulch_v_bark • 2 points • 2025-04-22 00:21 UTC

I hate when this happens because it implies that when I see a comment I disagree with I could probably just read it more carefully and realize we’re actually in accord :/

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 4 points • 2025-04-21 23:52 UTC

Where do you get these absurd numbers from? I can generate a 1080p image in stable diffusion in about 2 minutes localy on my PC and that has a 800w power supply. No, generating images does not take a million times more power than a google search, even if you only count what your browser does and not the google servers power demand.

Yes thats ignoring training the model, but thats a one time thing, so if you want to include that you have to divide it by the amount of pictures that specific model will generate.

I dont know where you got these unrealistic numbers from, but they are clearly wrong just like most of the claims about water usage are totaly blown up.

u/angel0fdespair • 1 points • 2025-04-21 23:40 UTC

that's actually fascinating, never catch me using ai imaging again. does using services for conversational ai like chat gpt also impact the earth?

u/Lumpy-Notice8945 • 3 points • 2025-04-21 23:58 UTC

Dont belive every shit people write on the internet, you can generate a picture on your local PC in a minute or two with a decent GPU, yes it uses electricity, and yes training the models uses up more power than just a regular laptop does, but so does using google search. But other than google training an AI is a one time thing(for each version that gets released every year or so). So you can compare it to building a car and then driving it, melting steel and so on costs a lot of electricity too and depending on how you generate that electricity you can argue that thats emiting CO_2 and using water too. AIs do use power compared to many other industry, but if you want to not harm the environemnt i recomemd you try to not use a car instead.

u/N4meless24- • 2 points • 2025-04-21 23:49 UTC

Yes, it is of a similar intensity, just used by a different part of the computer.